From the Political Behavior Archive to the Data Science Center

An institutional history of UCLA's social science data archive, 1961–present

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Introduction

This is the history of one job at UCLA: keeping research data so that people can find it, use it, and still rely on it years later. That job has been done here since 1961, sixty-five years now, under five different institutional homes and at least as many names. It is not a straight line. The unit's name, reporting line, and formal scope changed again and again. The work did not. A 1961 archive of punch-card survey data and a 2024 platform that processed 2.9 petabytes against about 20 terabytes of restricted voter data are recognizably the same work, done now for a much larger campus and with much larger stakes. This account tries to describe each era in its own terms rather than reading today's vocabulary backward onto it.

A companion document holds the full evidence: the people roster, project inventories, how the charts were built, and the discrepancies that are still open. It is at history-companion.qmd. This document is the narrative.

The history in 30 seconds

- UCLA's data archive goes back to **1961**, when political scientist Dwaine Marvick founded the Political Behavior Archive.
- It moved through several institutional homes over six decades. It was never one continuous organization, but the work continued as the campus around it changed: a survey center (1964), a research institute (1974), a formally-named archive within that institute (1977), the same institute renamed (about 2009) and then gone (about 2011), and finally its own unit inside the UCLA Library (2014).
- Two long-running survey series, **LAMAS** (1970–1976) and its successor **LACSS** (1992–2002+), are the closest thing to a continuous data product across that span, with **SCSS** covering the years between them.
- One person carried the whole span: **Elizabeth "Libbie" Stephenson** ran the archive from the late 1970s until her retirement in 2016, the clearest human through-line across five institutional homes.
- In **2018** the archive's umbrella became the **Data Science Center**, which carried the same work to new kinds of research data: 3D and spatial capture, restricted and sensitive datasets, and course material treated as a citable output.

A note on the author's position

Tim Dennis directed the Social Science Data Archive and the Data Science Center from April 2017 through 2026. This is his account of the archive's history, written to leave a record of work that ran for six decades and is now being reorganized out of its standalone form. It is a point of view. No institutional history is written from nowhere. The record it rests on is held to a plain standard:

- Claims about the recent decades are tied to cited institutional records, not to memory. Because the author took part in those years, they are held to a higher documentation standard than the earlier ones, not a looser one.
- Judgments about what worked and what was lost are marked as judgments.
- Claims about cause are kept within what the evidence supports.

- Work done by a team is credited to the team. Individuals are named where authorship, formal authority, or accountability makes it matter.

Evidence cutoff: 2026-08-31. Corrections and version history are in the project repository. More on the sources and their limits is in Methods and limitations.

Institutional timeline

Year	Milestone
1961	Political Behavior Archive founded (Marvick)
1964	Survey Research Center formed; PBA merges into its Archive Data Library
1974	Institute for Social Science Research (ISSR) established, incorporating the SRC
1977	The archive is named the Social Science Data Archive; Treiman designs its research-support framework
2014	MOU transfers SSDA from the Social Sciences Division to the UCLA Library
2018	The Data Science Center is formed as the umbrella program

1974 and 1977 are shown as separate events. ISSR (the parent institute) and the naming of the archive unit within it are four years apart, not one founding date. Dated by the sources in `dsc-evidence-registry/claims/`.

1961-1964: The Political Behavior Archive

Political scientist Dwaine Marvick, who had joined UCLA's faculty in 1954, founded the Political Behavior Archive (PBA) in 1961.[1] Rice and Southall place it in the field's founding cohort: UCLA's data service is the fourth-oldest social-science data library in their sample, after the Roper Center (1957), Berkeley (1958), and GESIS (1960), and ahead of ICPSR itself (1962).[2] What the PBA did was straightforward for its moment: it distributed survey and behavioral data from ICPR, the Roper Public Opinion Research Center, and local holdings to UCLA researchers.[3] A UC memorial calls Marvick "an early advocate and practitioner of computer applications to political data," which makes founding an archive a reasonable move for him, though no source found so far says why he did it in 1961 in particular. That silence is worth noting. Heinz Eulau's detailed 1999 memorial covers Marvick's career closely and never mentions the archive at all.[4]

[1] University of California Academic Senate, *Dwaine Marvick*, n.d., https://senate.universityofcalifornia.edu/_files/inmemoriam/html/dwainemarvick.htm.

[2] R. Rice and J. Southall, "Data Librarianship: Responding to Research Innovation," in *The Data Librarian's Handbook* (Facet, 2016), https://doi.org/10.29085/9781783301836.002.

[3] Jon Stiles and Libby Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences: Data Acquisition – Access – Management," *IFLA Social Science Libraries Section Satellite Conference* (University of Toronto), August 2008.

[4] Heinz Eulau, "Good-bye to Two Dear Friends: Warren Miller and Dwaine Marvick, A Personal Memoir," 1999 (`evidence/eulau-1999-miller-marvick-memoir.md`).

The following year, UCLA was among the founding member institutions of ICPSR. This one is confirmed against the primary document: Warren Miller's August 1962 memo to Rensis Likert making the case for the consortium names the members "as of July 30, 1962," and "University of California at Los Angeles" is on the list.[5] Two things often attached to that fact are shakier, and both come from the same place, the text Libbie Stephenson wrote for the archive's Dataverse page. It says there were eight founding members and that UCLA joined "through [Marvick's] efforts." That is the archive's own memory, not an independent record. A longtime ICPSR staff member's list from membership records has 22 original institutions; Miller's memo lists 21; and the "8" may instead be a "Committee of Eight" whose 1962–63 correspondence sits in ICPSR's own archive, a founding committee rather than the dues-paying roster. No document found so far, Miller's memo included, gives Marvick a formal role in the 1962 founding. His documented ICPSR involvement is governing-board service from 1964, then chair of the ICPR Council in 1966–67. What is documented is that Marvick and Miller were close friends and collaborators from the early 1950s at Michigan's Survey Research Center. That is a plausible route for "through his efforts," not proof of it.[6]

1964-1974: The Survey Research Center years

The archive's next home was UCLA's Survey Research Center (SRC), formed in 1964, which housed an "Archival Data Library" into which the PBA merged.[7] Marvick's own August 1964 proposal, *"Plans for the Development of a Social Science Archival Data Library in the UCLA Survey Research Center"*,[8] set out the concept directly, though the document itself has not turned up yet (see history-companion.qmd).

It is worth being precise here, because the archive's founding date gets told several ways and the confusion is avoidable. The archive work itself, taking in the datasets of the tape-sharing and mainframe era, keeping their codebooks, documenting them, and running a reference room where researchers could work out how to use machine-readable data, was a formal part of the SRC from 1964, and of the PBA before that. What did not exist yet was a named unit with its own staff line and consultative services. Stiles and Stephenson say the SRC's Archival Data Library ran "on a reference-room basis only." The name and the formal unit come in 1977. The work is older than the name.

One detail here is unresolved. The archive's own account, the text Libbie Stephenson wrote for its Dataverse page, puts the 1964 SRC arrangement "under the direction of Eve Fielder." A published obituary says Fielder became SRC's first director only in 1976. So either SRC ran from 1964 under someone else, or the account compresses two events (see history-companion.qmd).[9]

[5] Warren E. Miller, memo to Rensis Likert, August 1962 (`evidence/miller-1962-considerations.md`), the actual founding document rather than a later description of it. Cross-checked against Erik Austin's ICPSR founding-members list (`evidence/icpsr-founding-members-austin.md`). The "8 members" and "through his efforts" phrasing is from `evidence/ssda-harvard-dataverse-about.md` (written by Stephenson).

[6] Heinz Eulau, "Good-bye to Two Dear Friends: Warren Miller and Dwaine Marvick, A Personal Memoir," 1999 (`evidence/eulau-1999-miller-marvick-memoir.md`).

[7] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences".

[8] Dwaine Marvick, *Plans for the Development of a Social Science Archival Data Library in the UCLA Survey Research Center*, 1967.

[9] The "1964, under Eve Fielder" claim comes from the archive's own Dataverse-page text (`evidence/ssda-harvard-dataverse-about.md`, written by Stephenson) and is repeated in the 2017 internal decks. The conflicting obituary date is in the 2026-07-31 research pass (`evidence/deep-research-report.md`). Not yet resolved against SRC's own records or the relevant UCLA General Catalog.

The SRC's main data product during this decade was the Los Angeles Metropolitan Area Surveys (LAMAS): ten waves, 1970–1976, a shared omnibus survey run about twice a year with questions submitted by different researchers.[10]

The decade's clearest mark came from outside the archive. Around 1970 the UCLA Library's Public Affairs Service, under Mary Ryan, bought 1970 census tapes from DUALabs. It was the library's first move into numeric data, and it was cited nationally as an early case of a library taking on machine-readable data.[11]

1974-1977: ISSR, and the archive gets a name

The Institute for Social Science Research (ISSR) was established in 1974, taking in the SRC and its archival data library, under founding director Howard E. Freeman, a medical sociologist.[12] Three years later, Associate Director Donald Treiman did what several sources describe in different words. He took the archival data library that had run "on a reference-room basis only," designed its research-support framework (the model of working alongside a project across its whole life cycle that the archive still gives as its mission), and formalized it into a named service unit, the Social Science Data Archive (SSDA), with its own Data Archivist line.[13] An OECD international directory dates the "ISSR Data Archive at UCLA" to December 1977, for quantitative research and "primarily secondary analysis."[14]

So 1977 is not the archive's founding. The archive dates itself to 1961, and the work ran without a break through the PBA and the SRC's Archive Data Library. 1977 is when it was named, given a staff line, and built out from a reference room into a service that consulted. The sources that look like they disagree are describing different parts of that one change. The archive's own account (Stephenson) credits Treiman with the framework and does not mention ISSR. The 2017 decks and the OECD directory name ISSR as the home. The team's published book chapter[15] says "as part of the Survey Research Center," which by 1977 was a component of ISSR. What still needs a documentary check is the exact reporting line, whether Treiman's 1977 framework sat directly under ISSR or under the SRC within ISSR. The year and the continuity are not in question.

One episode from around 1980 runs against the direction most of this history moves in. When the UCLA Library decided not to buy 1980 census tapes, ISSR and SSDA took them on instead, with all the support and storage that came with them.[16] Numeric-data stewardship moved from the Library to the Archive, the reverse of what would happen in 2014.

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[10] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences"; Martin Pawlocki and Elizabeth Stephenson, "A Micro Based Tape Information System," *IASSIST Quarterly*, 1988, 25–40.

[11] Judith Rowe and Mary Ryan, "Library Service from Numerical Data Bases: The 1970 Census as a Paradigm," *College & Research Libraries* 35 (1974): 7–15; Sue A. Dodd, "Toward Integration of Catalog Records on Social Science Machine-Readable Data Files into Existing Bibliographic Utilities: A Commentary," *Library Trends* 30, no. 3 (1982): 335–61.

[12] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences".

[13] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences"; Pawlocki and Stephenson, "A Micro Based Tape Information System".

[14] *Social Sciences for a Digital World* (OECD, 2000), an international directory that dates the ISSR Data Archive at UCLA to December 1977; cited in `evidence/deep-research-report.md`. The research pass also separates a 1976 step, the SRC being taken into ISSR, from the December 1977 step, SSDA being formally established as a named unit. A two-step transition rather than one 1977 event.

[15] Tim Dennis et al., "From a Data Archive to Data Science: Supporting Current Research," in *Data Science in the Library: Tools and Strategies for Supporting Data-Driven Research and Instruction*, ed. J. Herndon (Facet, 2021).

[16] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences".

1977-2014: SSDA under ISSR, then ISR, then on its own

The archive's 37 years under this umbrella were not one arrangement. They fall into three subperiods.[17]

- **ISSR proper (1977 to the late 2000s).** The archive was a service unit of the Institute for Social Science Research. Its directors were Howard E. Freeman (founding director, 1974–1981), Marilynn B. Brewer (from about 1983 until she left UCLA for Ohio State in 1993), and David O. Sears (1993–2008). UCLA's General Catalogs list SSDA as an ISSR component through at least 2005–07.
- **Institute for Social Research (about 2009 to 2011).** By the 2009–10 UCLA General Catalog the parent institute had been renamed ISR, with the same components (including the Data Archive) and a new website. The Survey Research Center is no longer listed among them; it had moved to a Health Services Research division in 2004. No director is named under ISR.
- **Standalone SSDA (about 2011 to 2014).** By the 2011–12 catalog neither ISSR nor ISR appears. The Social Science Data Archive is listed on its own, as a Social Sciences collection with its own site (`dataarchives.ss.ucla.edu`), and stays that way through 2013–14. No source records a formal dissolution of the parent institute or a single successor. The reporting line from here to the 2014 Library transfer is unresolved.

The recurring survey work carried on throughout, renamed and reshaped: the Southern California Social Survey (SCSS), then the Los Angeles County Social Survey (LACSS), which ran at least 1992–2002 (the full series detail is in history-companion.qmd). By the 1990s the archive had become, in its own staff's words, "the de facto campus-wide data service unit," serving public health, education, policy studies, law, and management, not only social science departments.[18] A surviving SSDA newsletter from about 1979 names Martin Pawlocki (programmer), Gina Jamison (the same person as today's DSC staff member Jina "Jamie" Jamison), and Shirley Lane, who had come from the UCLA Research Library's machine-readable 1970 Census project. The newsletter puts the archive in the Gayley Center Building by 1979, after an earlier stint in Franz Hall.[19]

The clearest human through-line for the whole era is Elizabeth "Libbie" Stephenson. ICPSR's retirement profile dates her UCLA start to about 1977, the year the archive became a named ISSR unit, and she is documented as staff and later Director through the 2014 transfer, retiring in 2016.[20][21]

[17] The three-subperiod structure rests on the digitized UCLA General Catalogs (2003–05, 2005–07, 2009–10, 2010–11, 2011–12, 2013–14), read in the 2026-07-31 research pass (`evidence/deep-research-report.md`, `site/issr-era.qmd`). Sears's 1993–2008 ISSR directorship is independently confirmed (his Wikipedia biography and UCLA psychology page). Still soft: Freeman's and Brewer's exact terms, and whether the ISSR-to-ISR rename had a formal date or authority (none found); Brewer's ISSR term is bounded at the end (she left UCLA for Ohio State in 1993, when Sears took over) but her start year is soft. Operational staff named in that pass but not archive-confirmed (Eve Fielder, Rita Engelhardt, Donald Witzke, Michael Greenwell, Madeleine De Maria, Tana Wong, and others) appear in an early-1980s UCLA earthquake-research report and the front matter of Citrin and Sears's *American Identity and the Politics of Multiculturalism*. See history-companion.qmd.

[18] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences".

[19] `evidence/newsletter-images-2017-deck.md`, photographed excerpts of an SSDA newsletter from about 1979 embedded in a 2017 internal deck. Jamie Jamison confirmed to Tim directly that "Gina Jamison" is her.

[20] Pawlocki and Stephenson, "A Micro Based Tape Information System"; Libbie Stephenson, "Social Science Data Files and Bibliographic Control: Contributions of Sue A. Dodd," *IASSIST Quarterly*, 2013; Jennifer Doty et al., "Learning to Curate," *Bulletin of the Association for Information Science and Technology* 40, no. 6 (2014): 31–34.

[21] `evidence/stephenson-icpsr-sources.md` corrects her retirement from 2014 to 2016 and dates her UCLA start to about 1977 from ICPSR's own materials; `evidence/pawlocki-stephenson-1988-iassist.md` independently

Her long run of work on bibliographic control, with Sue Dodd's scholarship, IASSIST, and ICPSR, is early data-citation practice under an older name: making data properly identified and findable. By 2013, right before the Library transfer, SSDA was already testing the DDI-Lifecycle metadata standard and Colectica curation software. It was moving toward modern research-data practice on its own. The era's clearest outside connection was across borders: the Intergenerational Stratification and Mobility File (ISMF), built with Harry Ganzeboom of the Free University in Amsterdam and Donald Treiman, and funded by the Netherlands Organisation for Scientific Research.[22]

2014-2018: The Library MOU, and a change of director

The MOU, effective 2014 and executed 2015, moved SSDA from the Social Sciences Division to the UCLA Library. The archive had already been standalone since about 2011; what changed in 2014 was the kind of home, from an academic division to a library. It carried 2.0 FTE, about $245K in permanent funds, and about $29K in subscriptions (ICPSR, Roper, UC Berkeley/SDA, Colectica/Algenta), plus a small foundation gift fund; staff who came across included Elizabeth Stephenson and Jina "Jamie" Jamison.[23] The stated purpose was to "expand access to the archive's expertise while modernizing its services," which reads as a mandate to grow the work, not just move it. The MOU also carried a consultation clause: if the Library later made "substantial changes to the operations of Social Sciences Data Archives," it was to meet with the Social Sciences Division and keep faculty access intact.

In April 2017 Tim Dennis was hired as Director of SSDA, succeeding Stephenson, whose own tenure reached back to the late 1970s.[24] That November he presented "Library Data Archive" to UCLA Library staff, already framing 1961 to 2017 as one continuous arc under the tagline "Providing archive and data services since 1961."[25]

The team then reworked the unit's goals and services using design thinking, with "the user as the scholar in need of research support" at the center.[26] In Spring 2018 the result became official: the unit was restructured and renamed the Data Science Center (DSC), with a new visual identity and a mission written to cover any discipline,

> to foster a welcoming research community by developing data literacy and foundational coding skills through consulting and education … supporting researchers throughout the full data life cycle: planning and data management plans; acquisition, storage, cleaning and usage; analysis; publication; curation; and preservation.[27]

SSDA became a named component of it. Per Tim, Todd Grappone, then the Library's AUL for Digital Initiatives and IT, handled the 2014 transfer, coined the "Data Science Center" name, and helped design the 2018 service model.[28]

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documents her as staff by 1986.

[22] Stiles and Stephenson, "Disappearing Disciplinary Borders in the Social Sciences".

[23] University of California, Los Angeles, *Social Sciences Data Archives-to-Library MOU*, 2014.

[24] Tim Dennis, personal account, 2026-08-09.

[25] Tim Dennis, *Library Data Archive*, 2017.

[26] Dennis et al., "From a Data Archive to Data Science".

[27] Dennis et al., "From a Data Archive to Data Science".

[28] Tim Dennis, personal account. Grappone's role in the 2014 transfer and the 2018 naming is not in any public source; it rests on the author's account as a participant. Grappone became University Librarian at UC Santa Barbara in July 2025.

2018-present: The Data Science Center

This is the era with the widest gap between the unit's size and its reach, and the era this history's author directed. It is written against institutional records and cited sources rather than recollection, and the judgments in it are marked as judgments. Working notes and the full evidence trail are in `evidence/library-era-2014-present.md` and history-companion.qmd.

Continuity, not rupture

The 2018 rebrand changed the unit's name and widened its scope. It did not replace what came before. `ucla-data-archive_old`, a repository built around the "Data Archive" identity, holding its collections policies, terms, and deposit and preservation practices, was created in July 2017 and actively maintained through May 2020, two years after the unit's formal name became "Data Science Center." The archive's core work, repository hosting, which descends directly from the LAMAS, SCSS, and LACSS series, ran under the new name the whole time. Jina "Jamie" Jamison, who came across with the archive in 2014, still leads that repository work today. She is the one human through-line across the whole Library era.

The growth over that span is easy to state. Staff went from 2.0 FTE at the 2014 transfer (a director and a data archivist) to five by about 2021, mostly by redesigning existing library positions rather than hiring new ones: a geospatial librarian moved in from another department and was rebuilt as a Spatial Data Science Librarian (Zhiyuan Yao), a data manager from the Library's IT division was rebuilt as a Data Science Facilitator, and a Digital Library programmer with a machine-learning background was recruited across divisions (Kristian Allen, a 0.5-FTE role, 2018–2024).[29] UCLA Dataverse went from 9 datasets and 229 downloads in January 2020 to roughly 1,600 datasets and more than 143,000 downloads by 2026.[30] The staffing did not grow in proportion. Part of how the unit absorbed the load is the student program described below; part is that some capacity was simply lost, a GIS position cut in 2024 and other roles ended, with the demand in those areas still there.

What stayed constant, and what changed

For six decades and five institutional homes the constant has been the same: keep research evidence findable, usable, and preserved, and extend that to whatever kind of evidence researchers happened to be producing. What changed after 2018 is the range of things that covers. Not only survey datasets now, but restricted and sensitive data that needs governed computation, geospatial data and aerial imagery, 3D and spatial capture, text corpora and computational text analysis, research

[29] Dennis et al. 2021 (Dennis et al., "From a Data Archive to Data Science") describes the redesign-not-hire staffing model. The specific position histories rest partly on the author's account. [NEEDS TIM: the Data Science Facilitator's name and dates; Leigh Phan's exact title and start; the 5-FTE peak year and the headcount at dissolution.]

[30] The "~1,600" resolves an apparent discrepancy. UCLA Dataverse holds about 376 datasets deposited directly at UCLA plus about 1,014 legacy Social Science Data Archive datasets harvested in and curated by Library staff, which is roughly 1,390 released, or 1,603 counting drafts and restricted deposits. UCLA's live-dashboard figure of about 377 is the directly-deposited slice. See `evidence/library-era-2014-present.md` §4.

software, and course material treated as a citable output.[31] Look back at that list and it tracks the field's own sequence, from data citation to open and FAIR data to open science to software curation to computationally intensive research support. That is a way of narrating what changed after the fact, not a plan anyone was working to. The sections below take the main strands one at a time.

The repository: UCLA Dataverse

The legacy SSDA collection had lived on Harvard's hosted Dataverse. In 2018 the DSC stood up a local UCLA instance, chosen for the same reasons the archive had chosen Dataverse in the first place: DDI metadata, the ability to restrict licensed data, and a curation ladder from self-service deposit to fully mediated. The DSC wired it to UCLA single sign-on, DOI minting, and preservation through the California Digital Library. Research groups run their own branded sub-collections inside it with DSC training. One deliberate choice was to harvest the legacy SSDA collection into the discovery layer rather than migrate it right away: keep it working first, move it later.

The collections DSC hosts now run well past social science. The UCLA Law Behind Bars Data Project covers COVID-19 in prisons, jails, and detention nationally, about 1,169 items. The Williams Institute's LGBT law-and-policy data, which DSC curation helped bring to ICPSR directly, includes TransPop, the first national probability sample of transgender people in the US. The Cotsen Institute and DIG archaeology collections hold about 6,360 items in DIG alone, more than the whole historical SSDA, LAMAS, SCSS, and LACSS corpus put together. DIG's own stated aim, to "expand citation practices" in archaeology, is the same bibliographic-control instinct Stephenson brought to the 1980s, applied to a different field at a much larger scale.

Running a repository also meant defending it. In early 2025, bots mass-downloaded UCLA Dataverse content, apparently to train a model, rotating across thousands of addresses to get around IP blocking. DSC identified the pattern and deployed an open-source filter that had it contained by mid-year.[32]

Governed computation: Redivis and the L2 voter file

Before this, UCLA had no compliant environment for restricted national datasets of this class, the multi-terabyte kind. There was no governed way to give a student access to a voter file, and no secure place to merge FERPA-, PII-, or PHI-restricted data at scale. To support that class of data, DSC selected and licensed Redivis, ran the institutional compliance review (Third-Party Risk Management, P3/P4 approval), negotiated access to the restricted datasets, piloted the platform

[31] The text strand shows up two ways. As teaching, DSC ran a well-attended line of workshops on qualitative and text data ("What do I do with all of this text? Cleaning and coding data for qualitative analysis," "Getting started with qualitative data analysis"), visible in the in-progress DSC instruction-stats integration. As consulting, the DSC team's 2021 chapter (Dennis et al., "From a Data Archive to Data Science") gives a worked example, helping a graduate student analyze ancient Buddhist texts with natural-language-processing techniques. Still thin: OCR of manuscripts and historical statistical series, and the text corpora bought with archive funds. [NEEDS TIM: those, plus the validated instruction figures once the integration is authorized.]

[32] Tim Dennis, self-reported (Statement of Professional Achievements, 2023–2025). The tool deployed was Anubis. [NEEDS TIM: a ticket or postmortem reference to anchor the dates.]

in 2022, and launched the governed service in January 2023. It set up a 50-seat model with data-use-agreement controls so that routine requests would not pile up on one person.[33]

The main case is the L2 historic voter file, more than 10 TB of national voter history bought through the archive's gift fund. It arrived as thousands of fragmented state-level files, too large to store locally and too inconsistent to analyze. DSC pulled it into a single version-controlled national dataset, published with its own DOI (UCLA Library, *L2 Voter History and Demographic Dataset*, 2023, doi:10.60603/D33W2T) and presented at FORCE11 2024 by Redivis's CEO alongside the doctoral student who curated it, Graham Straus. Straus put the institutional point plainly: "What happens when I leave UCLA? Will people know how the dataset was constructed? Yes!" Researchers use it directly across departments, in election administration, gentrification, Latino voting, and a project merging the voter file with UCLA medical records to study health and voting. Recorded processing on the platform grew from 444 GB in its first year to 2.9 PB in 2024; those figures measure platform activity, not data held (holdings are about 20 TB). DSC provided the environment and the access. The scholarship stayed with the researchers. The point of it is not an "AI" story. It is that stewardship came to include governed computation, not only acquiring and describing open files.

Teaching at scale, and open science

Instruction went through three distinct eras, and the shift between them was reactive, not planned. With two staff and tens of thousands of potential learners, the unit joined The Carpentries in 2017 and used the membership to build an instructor community rather than hire one; Tim founded UCLA Carpentries in 2018 and spent its first two years teaching locally, one campus, in person. COVID changed the economics of that model overnight: travel-based cross-campus training became impossible, but virtual delivery made cross-campus *coordination* suddenly cheap. Tim co-founded the systemwide UC Carpentries network in 2020 in direct response to that constraint, not as a planned expansion. What followed was sustained, not temporary: nine workshops in September 2024 alone drew 937 attendances across UCLA and partner UC campuses, and the 2025 series drew 558 attendees (139 from UCLA) across another nine sessions. The unit had gone from teaching its own campus to running system-scale infrastructure other campuses scheduled their own programming around, a change in kind, not just volume. As chair of Library Carpentry's Curriculum Advisory Committee since 2022, Tim moved several lessons into the official worldwide curriculum, among them a Data Management Plans lesson aligned to the NIH data-sharing policy.

The IMLS grant RE-252335-OLS-22 ($237,839, Tim as Project Director)[34] treated course material itself as a citable research output: 15 peer-reviewed open-science lessons against 14 proposed, each with a Zenodo DOI, CRediT contributor roles, ORCID identifiers, and Citation File Format metadata, built by 27 authors across 14 teams. It is the clearest case of the software-curation and open-science strands in this era, and, because a federal award can be checked without anyone's account of it, the one with the firmest outside evidence.

[33] Platform and governance detail: Tim Dennis, Statement of Professional Achievements and Data Summary, 2023–2025, self-reported. The DOI, the FORCE11 presentation (Mathews & Straus 2024, doi:10.5281/zenodo.13181256), and the publication venues are the independently checkable parts. Launch: piloted 2022, governed service launched January 2023 (confirmed by Tim 2026-09-02; reconciles the July-2022 / January-2023 sources).

[34] Institute of Museum and Library Services, *RE-252335-OLS-22: Lessons for Librarians in Open Science Principles and Methods*, Grant award record, 2022, https://www.imls.gov/grants/awarded/re-252335-ols-22.

Tim is also Co-PI on the $1.85M Sloan Foundation grant that established the UC OSPO Network, a six-campus effort to treat open-source software as real scholarly infrastructure. That grant funds the network, not DSC. What DSC got out of it is a local UCLA open-source program office, the lead on the network's education work, and shared services (licensing guidance, a repository browser, a summer student research program). The need is concrete: a 2025 scan of about 81,000 UC-affiliated code repositories found that 77.5% carried no license at all.

Spatial data, 3D capture, and the Lux Lab

Geography has consistently been the unit's largest single workshop audience. Before the GIS position was cut in 2024, DSC's geospatial librarian handled 70 to 80 booked consultations a year, started the systemwide UC GIS Week, ran UC GIS workshops that reached hundreds of people, managed the LARIAC regional aerial-imagery holdings (bought through the archive's gift fund), and worked with UC San Diego and UC Santa Barbara on geospatial discovery for Dataverse. DSC also ran UCLA's campus ArcGIS Online platform. It grew to more than 7,000 accounts and over 3,000 active users a year, and since the position was cut it has run past its licensed storage with no assigned administrator.[35]

The clearest case of the archive's work reaching a genuinely new kind of research object is Doug Daniels and the Lux Lab. Daniels joined the Library in 2013 and the DSC team in 2020 as Emerging Technologies Librarian. He runs UCLA's point-cloud visualization service (pointcloud.ucla.edu, built on Potree), is FAA-certified for drone work, and has built up a run of 3D-capture projects across archaeology, medicine, and cultural heritage: Easter Island Moai models feeding a Cotsen Institute atlas, cadaver-arm scans now taught in History of Medicine, a 3D-printed surgical guide in use at the medical center, drone-LiDAR surveys in Cambodia and Iceland, and, with DataSquad students and the Vietnamese Heritage Museum, a public 3D narrative of a refugee family's escape by sea. He was named a UCLA Librarian of the Year for 2026. His work also runs straight back to the donor relationship: he scanned Powell Library itself and showed the lab's work to the Powell Society donor circle.

DataSquad: a student research workforce

DataSquad, modeled on a program at Carleton College, began in 2020 on a Powell gift that paid the first cohort's salaries and laptops, with the Library adding funds in 2023 to expand it. It pairs undergraduate and graduate consultants with staff on sustained project work. Reportable project engagements grew from a handful in 2023 to more than a hundred in 2025, as departments started planning research around its availability rather than calling it only when something broke. Of the ten students whose outcomes after graduation were tracked in the 2023–2025 period, all went into data or technical roles, with McKinsey, Amazon, AIG, Stanford, and CVS Health among the destinations. The model has been picked up elsewhere through a DataSquad International network. Its research contributions are in the spotlights under Research impact.

[35] GIS consultation counts and the ArcGIS figures: DSC statistics and Tim Dennis's Data Summary, 2023–2025, cross-checked against an OARC governance report (Dec 2025) for the account totals. [NEEDS TIM: when and from whom DSC took over ArcGIS Online administration; LARIAC vintages and who serves that data now; and the OCR / text-corpus / digitized-document work, which is barely documented in what's been gathered.]

People and funding

Much of this era's expansion ran on Norman Powell's philanthropy: a data-scientist position, a deep-learning machine and DSC space in the Young Research Library, and DataSquad's seed funding, all separate from his dated $5M December 2016 gift that endowed the University Librarian position. A quieter piece of budget work mattered nearly as much. DSC moved the archive's large recurring subscriptions, ICPSR and Roper, off its own gift fund and onto the Library's general membership budget, the way research libraries usually treat major database memberships. That freed the archive's original fund to cover the cloud costs of Dataverse and the point-cloud platform. The move was possible because one role could see the archive's budget and the infrastructure budget at the same time.[36]

The people who carried the work were Jamie Jamison (repository and curation), Doug Daniels (3D and emerging technology), Leigh Phan (programmer to data scientist over this period), a GIS/spatial librarian, a data-science facilitator, and the rotating DataSquad students. The full roster, with what is and is not independently documented, is in history-companion.qmd.

People and stewardship

This lists the founders, the formal leaders, and the people who kept the operation running over a long stretch. The full roster, including shorter-tenure staff and rotating collaborators, is in history-companion.qmd.

The ISSR-era entries rest on the digitized UCLA General Catalogs and corroborating published sources (see the 1977–2014 section). Sears's directorship dates are independently confirmed; Freeman's term and Brewer's end date are firm; Brewer's start year and the operational staff below the director line are still soft.

Name	Role	Documented span	Note
Dwaine Marvick	Founder, Political Behavior Archive	1954 (joined UCLA) to 1999 (d.)	ICPSR governing board from 1964, Council chair 1966–67; personal role in the 1962 founding not documented
Howard E. Freeman	Founding Director, ISSR	1974–1981	Medical sociologist; co-author of *Evaluation: A Systematic Approach*; d. 1992
Marilynn B. Brewer	Professor of Psychology and Director, ISSR	~1983 to 1993	Social psychologist; left UCLA for Ohio State in 1993

[36]The direction of the subscription move and the reinvestment into infrastructure is confirmed by budget ledgers and AWS cost records; the full dollar trail, and the dates two other subscriptions were dropped, is only partly reconstructed. See `evidence/library-era-2014-present.md` §13. [NEEDS TIM: the budget records for the infrastructure and dataset purchases funded from the freed line.]

Name	Role	Documented span	Note
David O. Sears	Director, ISSR	1993–2008	Political psychologist; UCLA Dean of Social Sciences 1983–1992
Donald Treiman	ISSR Associate Director; formalized SSDA	1975–1977 (Assoc. Director); UCLA Professor 1977–2004	Later co-built the ISMF with Ganzeboom and Stephenson
Mary Ryan	Director, UCLA Library Public Affairs Service	1970s–1980s	Ran the library's first numeric-data service, the 1970 census tapes
Elizabeth "Libbie" Stephenson	Archive staff, later Director	~1977 (per ICPSR), or 1986 (other sources), to 2016 (retired)	Longest tenure; MLS UCLA 1977; IASSIST President 1995–97; led the 2012–2014 ICPSR curation project
Martin Pawlocki	Programmer	in the ~1979 newsletter; 1987–88 (tape information system)	Co-authored the 1988 IASSIST Quarterly paper with Stephenson
Shirley Lane	Programmer / technical consultant	~1979	Came from the Research Library's machine-readable 1970 Census project
Jina "Jamie" Jamison	"Gina Jamison" in the ~1979 newsletter; tape/mainframe management, later Collection Manager, DSC	~1979, then continuous from before the 2014 MOU to the present	Left ~1979 for an MFA, returned; leads UCLA Dataverse
Tim Dennis	Director, SSDA (Apr 2017); Director, DSC	2017 to present	Succeeded Stephenson; founded UCLA Carpentries (2018), co-founded UC Carpentries (2020), founded UCLA DataSquad (2020)
Doug Daniels	Helpdesk Specialist, then Emerging Technologies Librarian, DSC	2013 to present (DSC team 2020)	UCLA Librarian of the Year 2026; runs the "Lux Lab"
Leigh Phan	Programmer, later Data Scientist	2018-present era	Role evolution per Tim

Name	Role	Documented span	Note
Norman Powell	Philanthropic donor	gifts across several years, mostly undated	Funded a data scientist position, a deep-learning machine and DSC space, and DataSquad seed funding; separately, $5M (Dec 2016) endowing the University Librarian position

Research impact

Two different things get measured here, and they answer different questions.

Historical traces of reuse

Holdings activity shows when the archive's deposited datasets were originally collected, by decade. It stands in for how busy the archive was. Citation evidence shows which of that data is documented as having been used in later published research. It stands in for downstream value, not for the archive's own activity. The two do not share a scale and should not be read against each other: a decade of heavy collecting does not have to produce more citations, and citations can arrive, and here do arrive, decades after collection.

Decade	Datasets collected
1960s	69
1970s	124
1980s	120
1990s	130 (peak)
2000s	87
2010s	5

571 datasets in the Harvard Dataverse SSDA collection, bucketed by the survey year in each title, not the Dataverse "published" date (a uniform 2015–2018 migration artifact; full method in the companion). Measures holdings activity, not usage or citation.

Citation evidence, by survey series (citing publications in ICPSR's Bibliography of Data-related Literature, searched by study number, 2026-08-09):

Series	Citing publications found
LACSS	2011, 2021, 2025
LAMAS	none in the queried index
SCSS	not measurable; never deposited in the queried index

Evidence of indexed citation, not a full estimate of use. Absence from the index does not mean a series went unused, especially for LAMAS (1970s) and SCSS, which predate modern data-citation norms by decades.

Publications behind the LACSS citations:,[37],[38].[39]

Contemporary research enabled

The 2018-present section above covers the infrastructure (Dataverse, Redivis, the Carpentries and open-science work, the spatial and 3D services) and the funding behind it. What that infrastructure carried, with the independently checkable part called out:

Case	What's independently checkable
Redivis / L2 restricted data	Publication venues (APSR, PNAS, BJPolS, AEJ), a public dataset DOI, a public FORCE11 presentation
IMLS open-science grant	A federal grant award record, public lesson repositories, Library Carpentry's own adoption record
Carceral Ecologies (Nicholas Shapiro)	DSC/DataSquad multi-year support on a helicopter-surveillance dataset; national media (*LA Times*, *The New Yorker*, *Bloomberg*); pilot data behind the $5.07M Dana Foundation grant (2023) that established the UCLA and Charles R. Drew Dana Center for Neuroscience & Society, where Shapiro is Director of Research
BioCritical Studies Lab (Terence Keel)	Multi-year DataSquad work on a US deaths-in-custody dataset; a 2024 UCLA Public Impact Research Award; DSC's work credited in Keel's book *The Coroner's Silence*
Refugee Material Culture Initiative (Kelly Nguyen)	Doug Daniels + DataSquad, with the Vietnamese Heritage Museum; a public 3D digital narrative
DataSquad	Student outcomes for the ten tracked graduates (data/technical roles); the projects above drew independent national coverage

[37] Sarah Allen Gershon and Adrian D. Pantoja, "Patriotism and Language Loyalties: Comparing Latino and Anglo Attitudes Toward English-Only Legislation," *Ethnic and Racial Studies* 34, no. 9 (2011): 1522–42.

[38] Ruth E. Zambrana et al., "Analysis of Latina/o Sociodemographic and Health Data Sets in the United States from 1960 to 2019," *Health Education & Behavior* 48, no. 3 (2021): 320–31.

[39] Angela Gutierrez, "Latino Tu Latino Yo: Group Threat and Group Consciousness in California," *Political Research Quarterly* 78, no. 1 (2025): 264–76.

Methods and limitations

The author's position is stated up front, in "A note on the author's position." Tim Dennis directed the unit for the recent decades this history covers, and is separately the author of documents (a grant proposal, reorg-response material) that use some of the same facts for advocacy. A repository boundary does not change that. What this project does instead:

- The author's role, and this project's relationship to `ospo_datasquad_grant`, are stated plainly rather than left for the reader to find.
- Facts are sourced to a claim register (`dsc-evidence-registry`), not asserted from memory. See `claims/ssda-*`, `claims/icpsr-*`, `claims/issr-*`, `claims/dennis-*`, and `claims/dsc-*` there for what is verified, disputed, or self-reported.
- Documented facts are kept separate from interpretation. Discontinuities, gaps, and contested points are stated as such rather than smoothed over. See README.md "Known gaps" and history-companion.qmd "Open discrepancies."
- `ospo_datasquad_grant` may cite this project's evidence, but it is not independent corroboration of a claim that traces back to the same author.
- Self-reported achievement claims: much of the 2018-present detail comes from Tim's and Doug's own internal personnel-review documents. These are treated as discovery sources, not as sole public evidence. Where independent corroboration exists (press coverage, award records, publication venues, grant award pages), the claim is included and the corroboration is what is cited. Where only the review document supports a claim, it is either left out or explicitly attributed as a self-reported account. See history-companion.qmd for what has been held to that standard.
- The evidence cutoff is 2026-08-31. An outside read for factual support and proportion is optional, at the author's discretion; if one happens, the reader is named in "A note on the author's position."

Sources

Numbered notes appear at the first citation of each source. The bibliography below is generated from `references.bib` via `chicago-notes-bibliography.csl`.

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The full evidence base, with per-claim detail and verification status, is in `evidence/` and `dsc-evidence-registry/claims/` in this repository. The full companion (roster, project inventories, methods, open discrepancies) is at history-companion.qmd.